Platform as Power, War as Spectacle:

Mapping Pro-War and Anti-War Discourse on Truth Social During the US-Iran Conflict

Muhammad Suhail Zeerak | Student ID: 210089799 DHS 622 | Dr. Alexei Abrahams | April 2026

In early 2026, the United States went to war with Iran. Mainstream media outlets rushed to produce simulations of a distant war, images of explosions and maps and talking heads manufacturing a legible narrative for domestic consumption.[1] But the media landscape of 2026 is not that of the Gulf War, which Baudrillard famously declared did not take place; or rather, took place only as image, as pure spectacle without referent.[2] Something has structurally changed. The proliferation of social media has fragmented the old vertical model of manufacturing consent that Chomsky and Herman described, where a small number of institutional gatekeepers controlled the downward flow of information to passive publics.[3] The flow is now horizontal, decentralized, and impossible to fully control.

Into this landscape, Donald Trump launched Truth Social on February 21, 2022. The backstory is straightforwardly Trumpian: banned from Twitter after January 6, he did what any thin-skinned billionaire would do and built his own platform. A place where the rules would be his rules, the audience his audience, and the algorithm (to whatever extent one exists) oriented around his image. Truth Social is, from the ground up, a medium designed to amplify one voice and organize a community around it. It is, in the most literal sense, a simulation of a public sphere, one in which the conditions of participation have been designed to produce a particular kind of political subject. Loyal, aggrieved, and oriented toward a single center.

This paper argues that the platform's logic becomes most legible during crisis. The US-Israel war on Iran of 2026 was exactly that kind of moment. It was a test of whether Truth Social could host genuine political disagreement, or whether its architecture would flatten dissent into irrelevance. The data collected for this study dares to suggest the latter. The platform cut in one direction. And even the voices that pushed back did so in a language that ultimately reinforced what they were ostensibly opposing.

---

[1] Jean Baudrillard, Simulacra and Simulation, trans. Sheila Faria Glaser (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 1994).
[2] Jean Baudrillard, The Gulf War did not take place, trans. Paul Patton (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1995).
[3] Edward S. Herman and Noam Chomsky, Manufacturing Consent: The Political Economy of the Mass Media (New York: Pantheon Books, 2002).

Methodology

The dataset was assembled by identifying 186 Truth Social accounts active during the conflict period, divided into three analytical camps: pro_war (figures publicly supporting the Iran strikes and aligned with unconditional US-Israel policy), anti_war (America First isolationists skeptical of the war and critical, to varying degrees, of AIPAC influence), and bridge (accounts like Tulsi Gabbard and JD Vance whose positioning was ambiguous or visibly shifting). Accounts were further divided into Tier 1 (45 accounts scraped more fully across the date range, yielding between 42 and 3,891 posts each) and Tier 2 (141 accounts scraped for up to 40 of their most recent posts). The dataset breaks down as 164 pro_war accounts, 19 anti_war, and 3 bridge, a ratio of roughly 8.6:1 pro_war to anti_war, which is itself a reflection of Truth Social's demographic composition rather than any analytical bias. The platform is, structurally, a conservative ecosystem in which pro-war voices are simply more numerous.

Data was collected using truthbrush, a Python library interfacing with Truth Social's Mastodon-compatible API, authenticated via a browser-extracted token to bypass Cloudflare rate limiting. All posts were stored in a PostgreSQL database with deduplication logic to handle incremental re-scraping. The scrape covers February 1 to April 14, 2026, the lead-up to and first weeks of the conflict. The final dataset contains 19,596 posts from the pro_war camp, 2,878 from the anti_war camp, and 306 from bridge accounts, approximately 22,780 posts across 186 accounts. Analysis was conducted using a FastAPI backend and a Plotly Dash frontend, providing interactive access to network analysis, LDA topic modeling, sentiment scoring, keyword tracking, engagement metrics, and AIPAC funding comparisons. All code is available at github.com/13abu/FinalProjectDHS622.

The Platform as Simulacrum

Before getting into the numbers, it is worth sitting with what Truth Social actually is, because the platform's structure shapes every finding that follows. Baudrillard's simulacrum, an image or representation that has no original, that precedes and produces the real rather than reflecting it, fits almost too well here. Trump's Truth Social posts about the Iran war are clearly do not report the conflict. They *are* the conflict, at least as it exists for the platform's users.

Consider the post from April 5, 2026, the fifth most-engaged post in the entire dataset with 108,287 combined likes and reblogs:

> *"WE GOT HIM! My fellow Americans, over the past several hours, the United States Military pulled off one of the most daring Search and Rescue Operations in U.S. History... This brave Warrior was behind enemy lines in the treacherous mountains of Iran, being hunted down by our enemies... WE WILL NEVER LEAVE AN AMERICAN WARFIGHTER BEHIND!"*

This reads more like a Spielbergian epic instead of a presidential announcement. The hero rescued, the enemy defeated, the president triumphant. There is no mention of the broader conflict, no casualties, no geography beyond the word "treacherous." The war exists here as pure narrative. Legible, satisfying, and entirely abstracted from the material reality of what was happening in Iran. Baudrillard wrote of the Gulf War that it was conducted entirely for television. It was a media event that produced its own reality rather than representing one. Trump's Truth Social posts carry this forward to the social media feed: the simulation, instead of running on CNN or on Fox, runs on his profile, and its audience does not watch but participates, likes, reposts, and extends it.
The "Power Plant Day" post, which received 108,848 engagement and was the fourth most engaged post in the dataset, pushes this even further:

> *"Tuesday will be Power Plant Day, and Bridge Day, all wrapped up in one, in Iran. There will be nothing like it!!! Open the F--kin' Strait, you crazy b-stards, or you'll be living in Hell - JUST WATCH! Praise be to Allah."*

The tonal coverage, military ultimatum into trolling into apparent religious invocation, is not incoherence. It is performance. The "Praise be to Allah" line is a joke at the expense of the people being bombed: imperial irony that treats the destruction of civilian infrastructure as content, as engagement bait. This is the war as meme. And the platform rewards it accordingly.

The single most engaged post in the dataset, with 127,125 combined interactions, is Trump announcing the death of Khamenei:

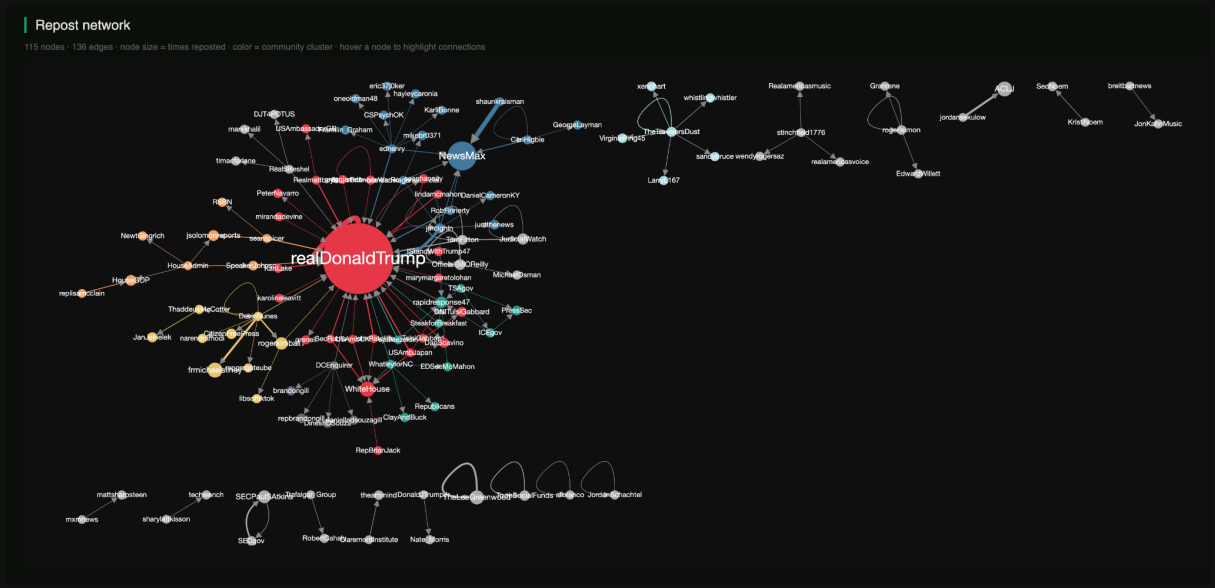
"Khamenei, one of the most evil people in History, is dead."

Note the capitalization of "History." Trump's language consistently inflates events to a mythological register; everything he does is historic, every enemy the worst in history, every victory the greatest. This is Stuart Hall's dominant encoding operating at the event horizon.[4] The preferred reading is encoded into the language itself. “Evil is dead, America did it, justice is served.” No further analysis is invited, permitted, or even necessary. The war has no bodies.

[4] Stuart Hall, "Encoding and Decoding in the Television Discourse" (CCCS Stencilled Paper No. 7, University of Birmingham, 1973),

The Network: A Platform Organized Around One Node

The repost network built from this dataset has 115 nodes and 136 edges. The dominant structural feature is not at all subtle.

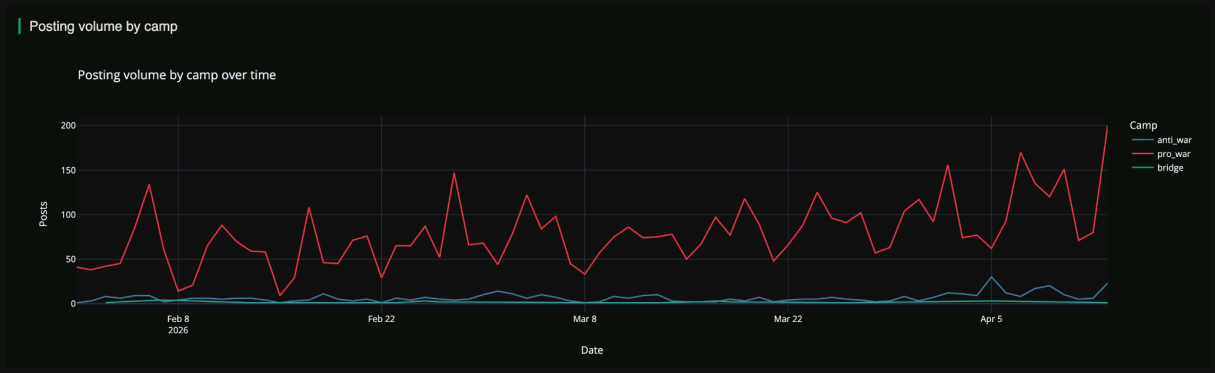


@realDonaldTrump is the overwhelming center of gravity. Virtually every account in the dataset, regardless of camp, has reposted him at some point in the period. This is itself a finding: even the anti_war accounts are embedded in a Trump-centric information ecosystem. They criticize specific policies but still circulate his content, directing their audiences back toward him, feeding the platform's central logic even while appearing to resist it.

NewsMax emerges as a secondary hub. A media outlet functioning as a content clearinghouse within the pro_war ecosystem. It has been variously described as conservative, right-wing, and far-right. The @WhiteHouse and @PressSec official accounts appear as nodes because seed accounts repost official government statements, demonstrating how tightly the pro_war camp aligns state apparatus and platform. The community detection algorithm identifies several clusters, but the key structural finding is how sparse the cross-camp edges are. The pro_war and anti_war camps are not in dialogue on this platform, but are parallel structures that happen to be on the same platform.

Volume, Activity, and the Manufactured Baseline

The volume asymmetry between camps is the most basic finding of this study, and also the most significant. The pro_war camp produced 19,596 posts in the dataset compared to 2,878 from the anti_war camp. That is a ratio of nearly 7:1. This gap was not created by the Iran conflict. Looking at the monthly data, the pro_war camp was already posting at roughly 4:1 above the anti_war camp in February 2026, before the conflict's intensity peaked. So the war amplified an existing imbalance rather than creating it.

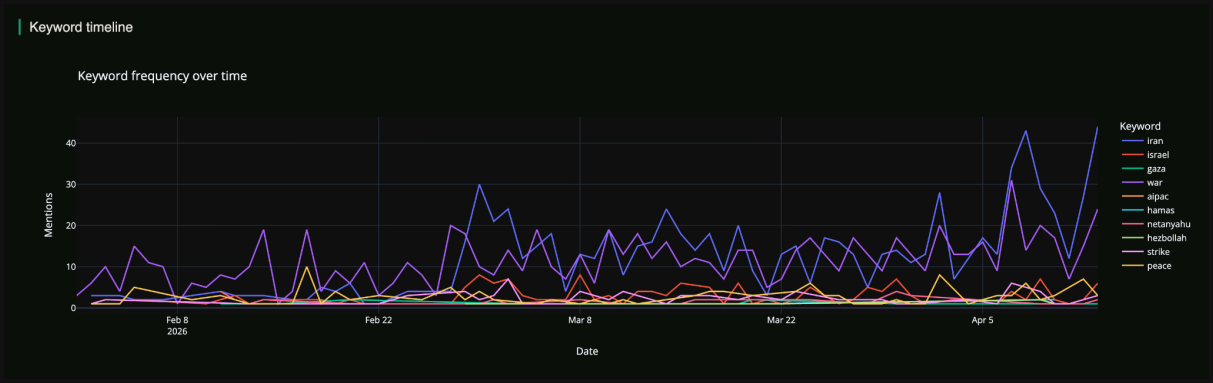


In April 2026, the month the conflict peaked, the pro_war camp posted 4,231 times against the anti_war camp's 474, a 9:1 ratio. The platform merely became more of what it already was during the war.

The posting volume numbers also reveal something about who is actually driving the pro_war camp's output. Trump posted 3,891 times in the dataset (before Cloudflare crashed the scraper), the most of any individual account. But Hannity posted 3,597 times, Bannon's War Room 2,368 times, and Trump War Room 1,538 times. The pro_war camp's information apparatus is vast and redundant. They have multiple accounts producing overlapping content at high volume, creating a kind of ambient saturation that makes the pro_war position feel like the default reality of the platform. The anti_war camp's most prolific account, RevolverNews, posted 1,305 times, already outpaced by Bannon alone.

What Each Camp Is Actually Talking About

The keyword breakdown by camp is very analytically interesting.



Across the full dataset, "war" appears 2,212 times and "iran" 1,370 times. But broken down by camp, the picture shifts significantly. The pro_war camp accounts for 1,285 of those "iran" mentions, 93.8% of all Iran references in the dataset, despite having only 68% of the accounts. The anti_war camp mentions Iran 79 times across 2,878 posts: a rate of 2.7% per post. The pro_war camp mentions Iran at a rate of 6.6% per post, more than twice as often.

Keyword	pro_war	anti_war	bridge
iran	1,285	79	6
war	1,938	234	40
israel	350	53	2
peace	565	31	22
aipac	2	4	0
tucker	28	50	0
ceasefire	117	4	3
gaza	81	11	2

This matters because it complicates the simple narrative that the anti_war camp is the camp talking about the war. They are not. They are talking around it. Their most engaged posts, Tucker Carlson's piece on manufacturing and trade, RevolverNews on the Obama marriage, MTG on the Charlie Kirk assassination, have almost nothing to do with Iran. The anti_war camp on Truth Social is not an anti-war movement. It is an anti-establishment constituency that happens to also be skeptical of this particular war, among many other things.

The AIPAC numbers are especially pointed. Across 22,780 posts, the word "AIPAC" appears 6 times. Four of those are in anti_war posts, two in pro_war posts. On a platform whose politician base received millions from AIPAC, Speaker Johnson alone received $618,530 in the 2024 cycle; the organization cannot be named. “He who must not be named.” This really is what truth social is all about. Dissent can surely exist at the margins, but certain structural critiques remain outside the horizon of what is even speakable.

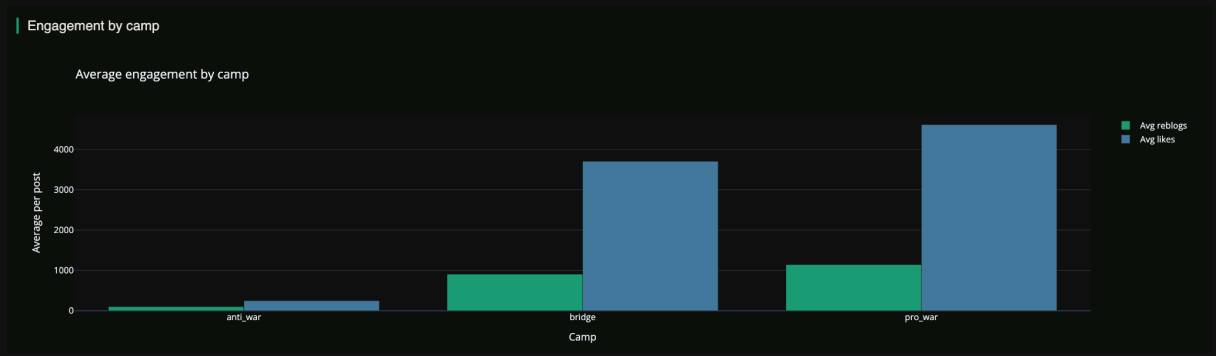
"Peace," by contrast, appears 618 times, but almost entirely in pro_war posts (565 of 618). A closer look at the content tells us why. Trump uses "peace" transactionally, in the context of hostage deals he is brokering, ceasefires he is negotiating, Nobel Peace Prizes he is receiving.

> "It was my Great Honor to meet María Corina Machado, of Venezuela, today. She presented me with her Nobel Peace Prize for the work I have done."

Peace here is a trophy awarded to the president by himself. The vocabulary of peace has been fully absorbed into the pro_war camp's image-making apparatus, and the anti_war camp, with only 31 "peace" mentions, has essentially ceded the term.

Engagement: The Algorithm's Verdict

The engagement data confirms this structural asymmetry:



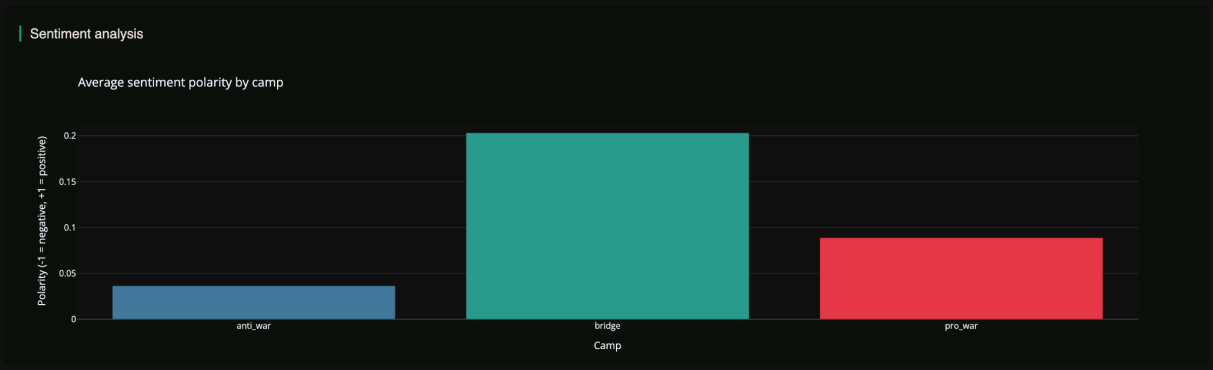
The pro_war camp averages 1,013 reblogs and 4,017 likes per post. The anti_war camp averages 253 reblogs and 814 likes per post, roughly one-fifth the engagement of the pro_war camp per post. The bridge accounts average highest at 1,354 reblogs and 5,972 likes, but this is almost entirely driven by JD Vance's posts, which consistently achieve very high engagement because of his position as Vice President.

The Iran-specific engagement breakdown is very enlightening. Pro_war posts that mention Iran receive an average of 4,713 engagement, comparable to their non-Iran posts at 5,052. Iran content neither hurts nor helps them; it is simply part of their consistent output. Anti_war posts that mention Iran receive only 679 engagement, compared to 1,078 for their non-Iran content. The anti_war camp's war content performs worse than everything else they post. The platform's audience, even the audience following anti_war accounts, is less interested in their Iran commentary than in anything else they say.

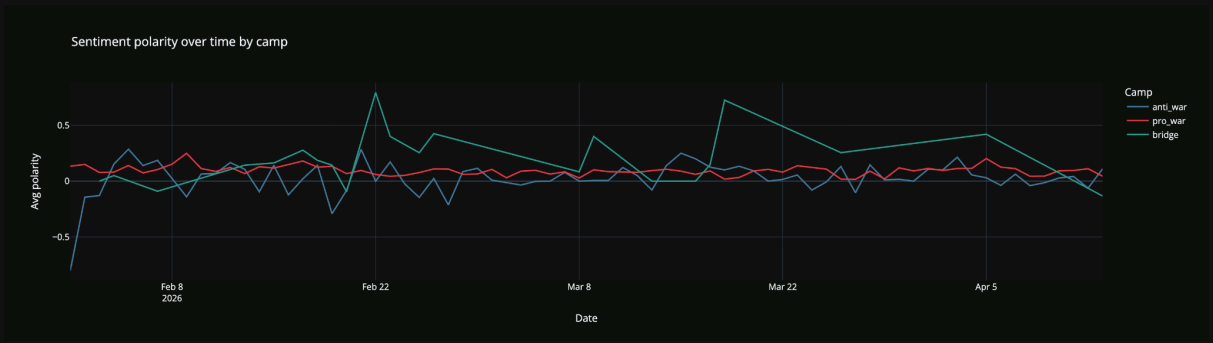
So the platform does not exactly suppress the anti_war camp. It simply doesn't amplify them when they say the thing that matters most. The algorithm, whatever form it takes on Truth Social, is not politically neutral.

Sentiment: The Affective Register of a Simulated War

Both camps post in mostly neutral-to-positive territory, which reflects the basic dynamics of speaking to your own audience rather than into a debate.



The pro_war camp scores slightly higher polarity than the anti_war camp, consistent with posting celebratory content about military victories. The bridge accounts show considerably more volatility, wide swings in both directions, reflecting the genuinely uncertain positioning of figures like Tulsi Gabbard navigating between institutional loyalty and audience skepticism.



The sentiment timeline captures the affective pulse of the conflict. The pro_war camp's positivity spikes around major military announcements, dips briefly when the conflict appears to escalate beyond control, then recovers as Trump frames each development as a victory. It is an emotional management exercise as much as a political one, the platform helping its core users feel that everything is going according to plan, that the simulation is proceeding as intended.

AIPAC and the Infrastructure of Alignment

The AIPAC contribution data provides a material layer beneath the platform's ideological performance.

Cross-referencing the 2024 AIPAC contribution records with the politicians in this dataset reveals a consistent pattern. Speaker Johnson received $618,530. Steve Scalise received $473,758. Tom Emmer received $454,467. Mike Garcia received $136,412. Brian Jack received $94,752. Jason Smith received $47,300. The lone anti_war politician in the dataset, Andy Biggs, received $800, less than many people spend on a laptop.

These politicians hold consistently hawkish foreign policy positions regardless of AIPAC money, and most of them would probably support Israel-aligned policies without it. But the pattern is not coincidental either. What the AIPAC data shows is that the pro_war camp's Truth Social activity, its volume, its consistency, its aligned messaging, is embedded in a broader infrastructure of financial relationships and institutional commitments that the platform itself makes invisible. Truth Social presents itself as raw, unfiltered speech, free from corporate influence. What it does not show you is who funded the speakers, who shares their incentives, and why certain positions are boosted.

The 6 mentions of "AIPAC" across 22,780 posts is, in this context, not just a curious data point. There is no better way to explain the platform's structural condition. The thing that cannot be named is the thing that most explains the shape of what can be.

The Anti-War Camp and Its Limits

Stuart Hall argued that a dominant encoding can be decoded in three ways: dominantly (accepting the preferred reading), negotiatedly (partially accepting, partially questioning), or oppositionally (rejecting it entirely). The anti_war camp on Truth Social produces a negotiated decoding of Trump's war, skeptical of this specific conflict, for reasons that remain entirely within the platform's nationalist framework.

Consider what the anti_war camp's top posts are actually about. MTG's highest-engagement post in the dataset is about confirming Kash Patel, Tulsi Gabbard, and Bobby Kennedy:

> *"Confirm Kash, Tulsi, and Bobby Kennedy!! If the Republican controlled Senate fails to confirm even one of these 3 GREAT patriots..."*

Tucker Carlson's most engaged post is about American manufacturing and trade policy. RevolverNews's top content is about the Obama marriage. These are not posts about Iran. They are not posts about the people being bombed. The anti_war camp's critique of the conflict never rises to the level of humanitarian opposition. It is, at its most pointed, a libertarian argument. America First, not America Everywhere, but America nonetheless.

This is what makes the platform a sickle with one edge. It does not prohibit dissent. It shapes the terms within which dissent is legible and rewarded. The anti_war camp's war content generates less engagement than their non-war content, which means that to grow their audiences they have better incentives to post about the Obamas than about Iranian civilians. The platform's logic nudges even its critics toward the politics of spectacle and grievance that define its core.

Trump's post naming Tucker Carlson, Megyn Kelly, Candace Owens, and Alex Jones as enemies of the state, *"they have one thing in common, low IQs,"* received 76,250 combined interactions and is among the top ten most-engaged posts in the dataset. Trump himself is encoding the anti_war position as stupidity: you cannot criticize this war without being an idiot who wants Iran to have nukes. It is a preemptive closure, a dominant encoding that silences negotiated readings by attaching them to personal inadequacy. That it received 76,250 interactions just shows that it worked.

Conclusion

Truth Social cuts in one direction. Its architecture, centered on a single dominant father-figure, organized around loyalty and grievance, rewarding spectacle over deliberation, produces a specific kind of political discourse, loud, affectively intense, and ideologically narrow. The data from this study confirms this at every analytical layer. Trump dominates the network. Pro_war content dominates the volume. The platform's keyword space is organized around his image, "trump" appears 6,670 times in the dataset, more than three times the frequency of "iran" at 1,370, more than five times "war" at 2,212, more than a thousand times "aipac" at 6.

The anti_war camp is real but structurally marginal, producing one-seventh the volume of the pro_war camp and generating less than one-fifth the engagement per post. More importantly, it is ideologically conservative in the same key as the pro_war camp. Skeptical of AIPAC not because of Palestinian or Iranian lives but because of American money and sovereignty; skeptical of the war not because bombing Iran is wrong but because it costs America something. This is the platform's most insidious achievement: it has made the limits of American conservatism look like dissent.

Baudrillard argued that the Gulf War did not take place, that it existed only as a media event, a simulation without a referent. Trump's Truth Social suggests a software update to this thesis for the social media era. The simulation has now been personalized, decentralized, and made participatory. The war on Truth Social is a feed, a cascade of engagement, a community organized around shared affect and shared loyalty. The Iranian dead remain, as ever, outside the frame, unrepresented in the keyword tables, invisible in the network graphs, absent from the topics that the platform's algorithm decided were worth amplifying. Not censored. Just unencoded. That is the difference, and it may be the more important one.